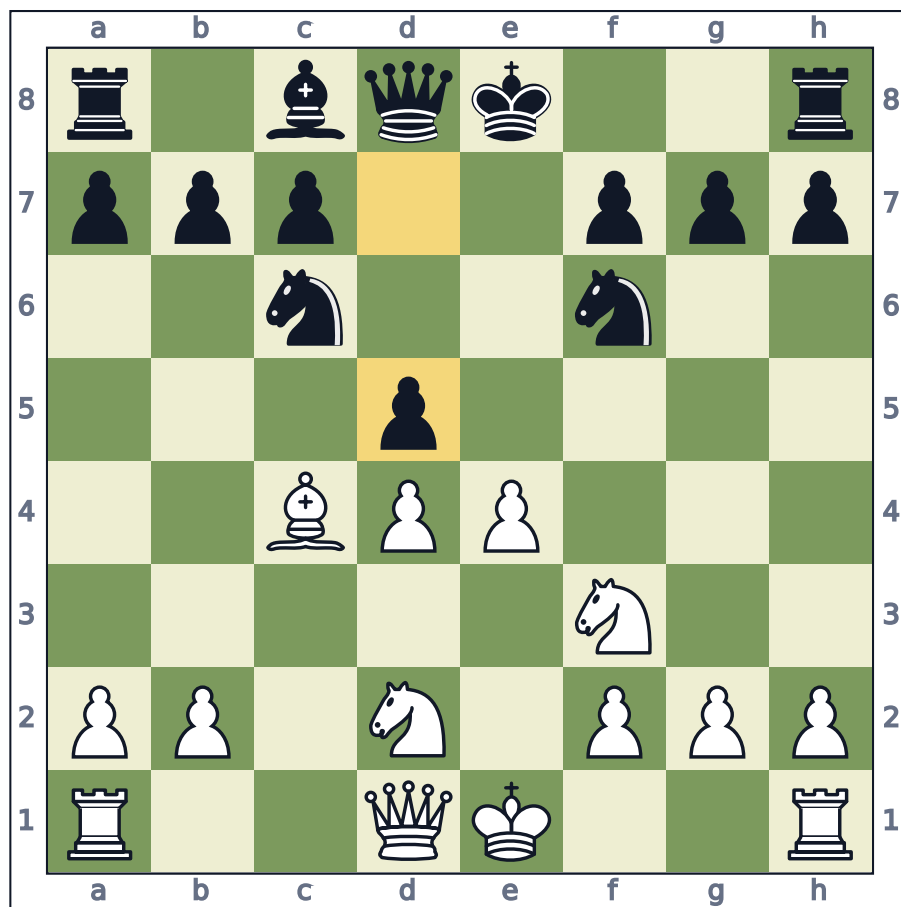


Italian Game

A ground-up visual course for practical play



Core route position - gold marks the last move

BOTH SIDES

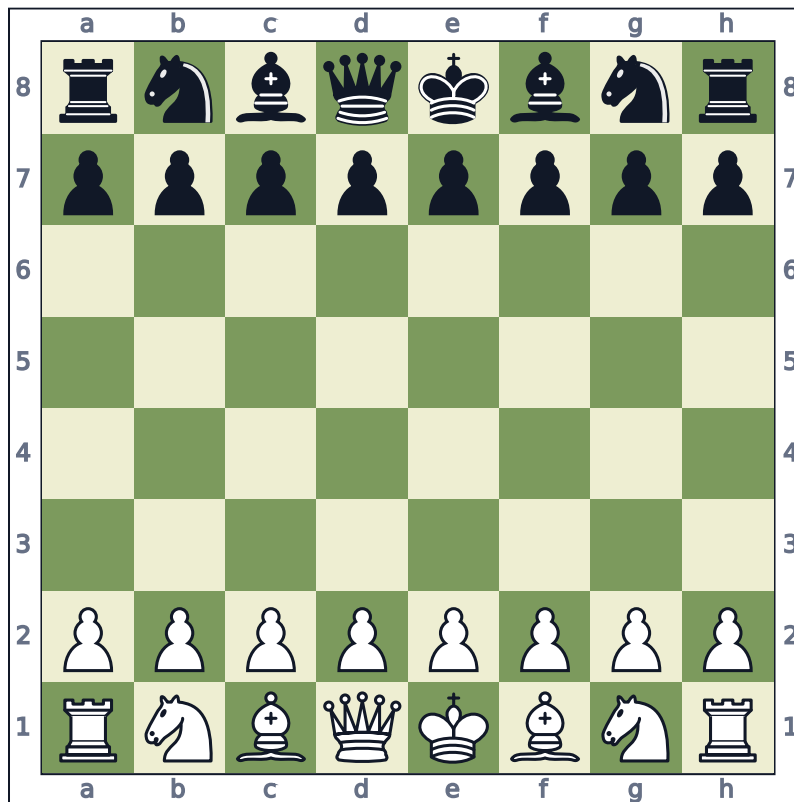
OPENING IDENTITY

Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.

ORIENTATION

Ground zero: read the board and the moves

White starts from ranks 1-2; Black starts from ranks 7-8. Files run a through h. Each lesson highlights the last move in gold so your eyes connect notation to the board.



Starting position - White to move

HOW ALGEBRAIC NOTATION WORKS

Nf3 means a knight moves to f3. B means bishop, R rook, Q queen, K king; pawns use only the destination square. An x means capture, + means check, and O-O means kingside castling.

YOUR FIRST ANCHOR

Say the first moves aloud, then point to every destination square:

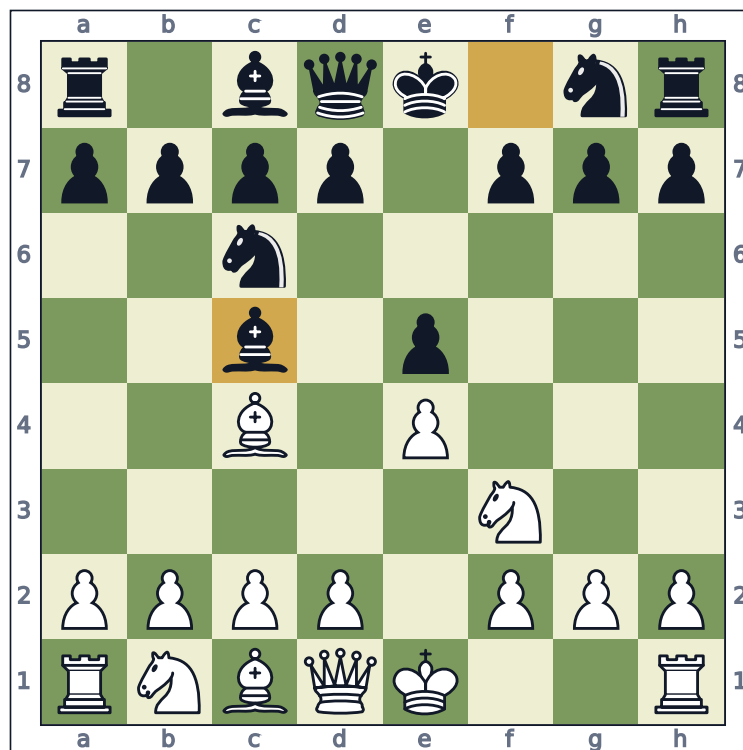
1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5

Course promise: Develop, build d4, castle, then attack.

MOVES 1-3

Lesson 1: the first conversation

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5



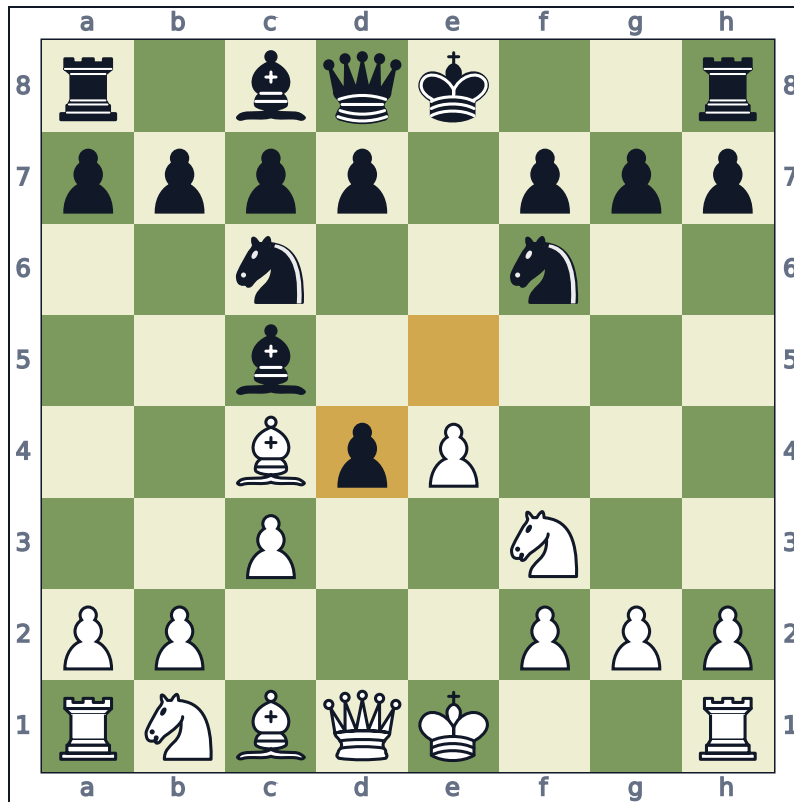
After 3. Bc4 Bc5

- 1. e4 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 1... e5 - Claims or challenges central space and opens a line for a piece.
- 2. Nf3 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 2... Nc6 - Develops a knight toward the center and increases control of key central squares.
- 3. Bc4 - Develops on an active diagonal, often adding a pin or long-range pressure.
- 3... Bc5 - Develops on an active diagonal, often adding a pin or long-range pressure.

DEVELOPMENT

Lesson 2: build the core position

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4



White to move

WHAT THE PIECES ARE BUILDING

Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.

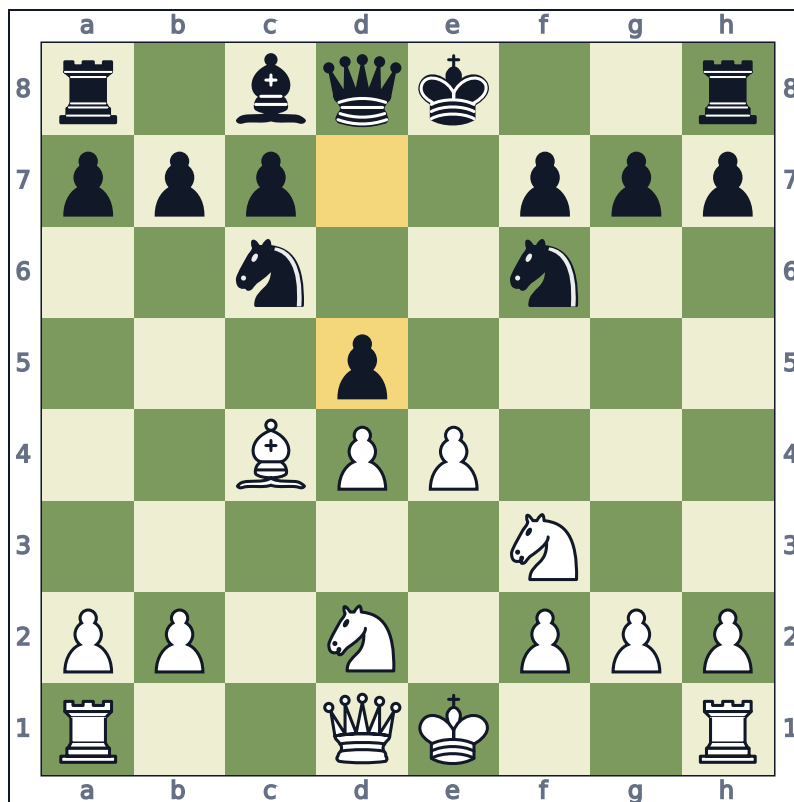
BEGINNER CHECKPOINT

Before copying the next move, ask: Is my king safe? Which piece is still at home? What changed in the center? Which pawn break is each side preparing?

CORE LINE

Lesson 3: complete the main route

1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Bc5 4. c3 Nf6 5. d4 exd4 6. cxd4 Bb4+ 7. Bd2 Bxd2+ 8. Nbx d2 d5



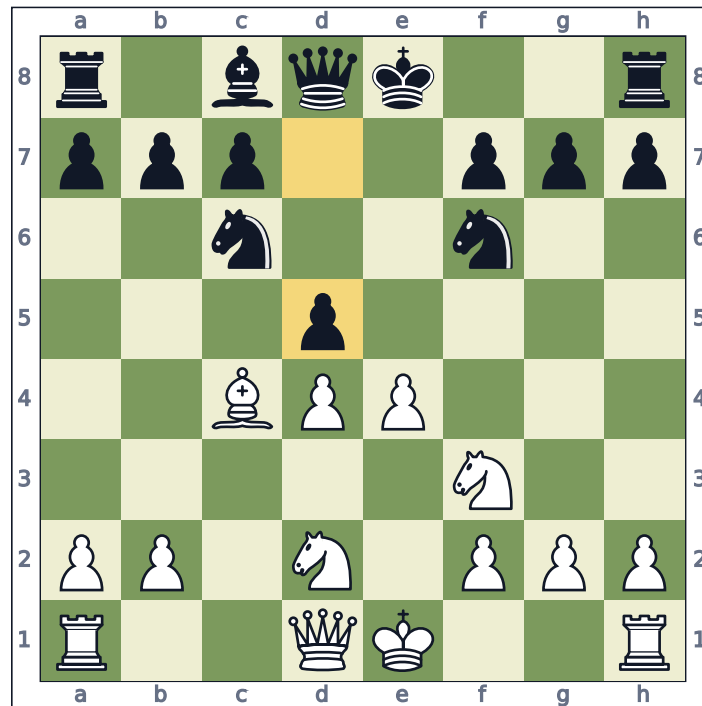
Core position - now plans matter more than memorized moves

DO NOT MEMORIZE BLINDLY

The route is a model, not a forced script. Its job is to teach this relationship: Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7. If the opponent deviates, preserve the same priorities until a concrete tactic changes them.

UNDERSTANDING

The position map: plans for both sides



Read plans from the pawn structure, not from the opening name

WHITE'S PLAN

Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it.

BLACK'S PLAN

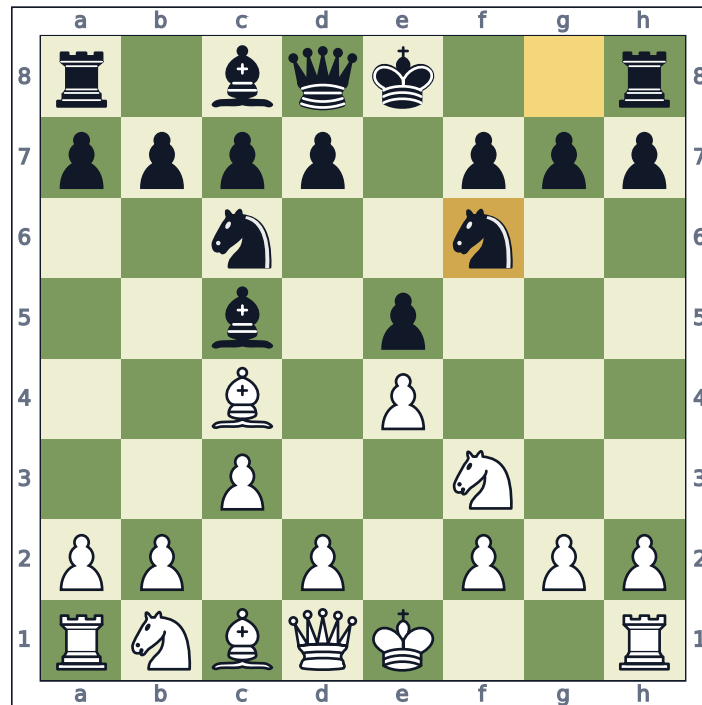
Meet d4 in the center, finish development, and avoid passive defense around f7.

THE LEVER TO REMEMBER

White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.

CALCULATION

Tactical literacy: what can suddenly change



Pause here - White to move

THEME

Pressure on f7, a central fork on e5, and pins on the e-file after castling.

COMMON BEGINNER ERROR

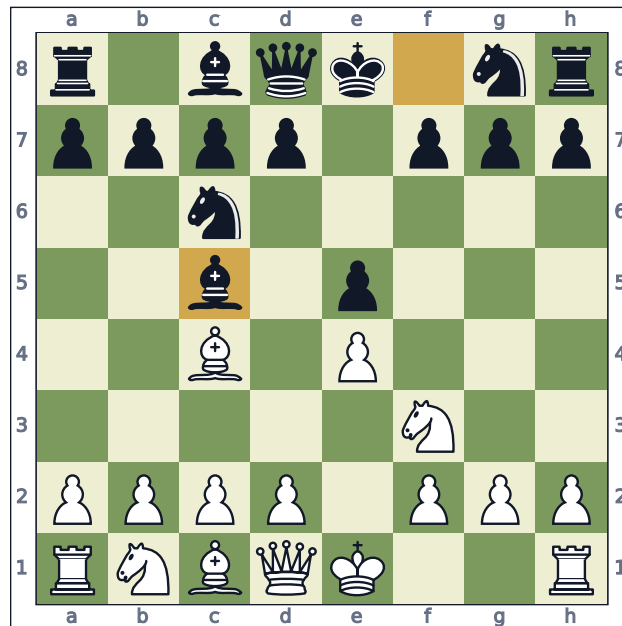
Attacking f7 repeatedly while the king remains in the center.

THREE-SECOND SAFETY SCAN

1. Checks against both kings. 2. Captures in the center. 3. Threats against loose or pinned pieces.

ADAPTATION

Decision tree: when the opponent leaves the route



A branch point - principles are your map

1. If the center stays fluid

Finish development and keep the opening identity in view: Fast development and a direct contest for d4 and f7.

2. If the center closes

Use the pawn-chain direction. Attack the base before making wing moves that cannot be supported.

3. If the center opens

Prioritize king safety, active pieces, and checks or captures before slow pawn moves.

4. If nothing is forced

Return to the planned lever: White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.

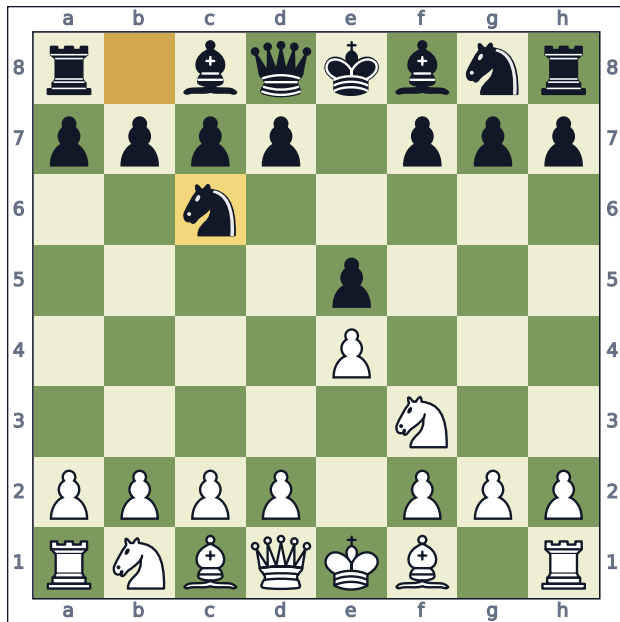
MEMORY SENTENCE

Develop, build d4, castle, then attack.

ACTIVE RECALL

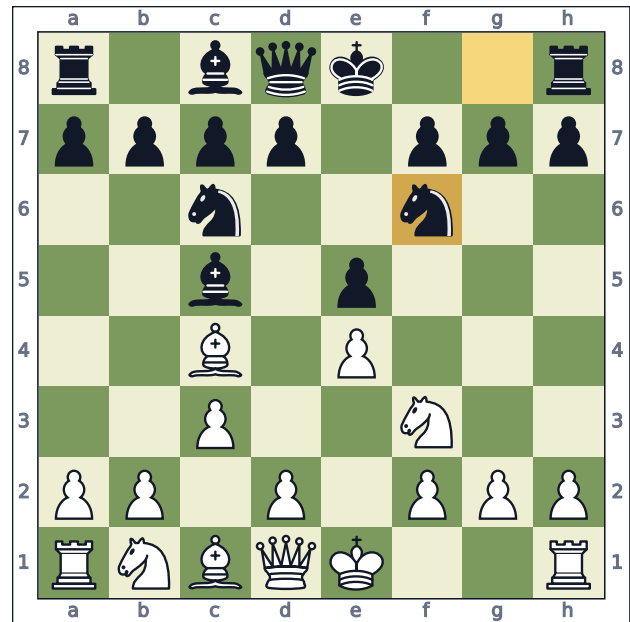
Recall test: answer before you turn the page

POSITION A



White to move

POSITION B



White to move

- A1. What is the next route move for White?
- A2. What opening problem does that move solve?
- B1. What is the next route move for White?
- B2. Name one plan for White and one plan for Black.
- C. State the thematic pawn break without looking back.

SCORING

5/5: replay from memory. 3-4/5: review Lessons 3 and 6. 0-2/5: return to Lesson 1 and rebuild the route slowly.

RETENTION

Answer key and a 14-day practice loop

POSITION A

Next route move: Bc4. Explain it using development, center, king safety, or a direct tactical need.

POSITION B

Next route move: d4. Then compare the position with the final core board.

PLAN AND BREAK ANSWERS

White: Build d4, castle, connect the rooks, and use e5 or d5 when the center allows it. Black: Meet d4 in the center, finish development, and avoid passive defense around f7. Lever: White's d4 is the main freeing break; Black often answers with ...d5.

14-DAY LOOP

- Days 1-2: replay the first three moves from both sides and name each move's job.
- Days 3-4: build the core position from memory; correct the first error, then restart.
- Days 5-6: say White's plan, Black's plan, and the pawn break without a board.
- Day 7: take the recall test. Record the score; do not count lucky guesses.
- Days 8-10: play three slow practice games, starting from the core position if possible.
- Days 11-13: review only mistakes and deviations that actually occurred in your games.
- Day 14: retake the test and write a one-sentence opening rule in your own words.